

CourseBridge — How It Works (Plain-Language Walkthrough)

A guide for everyone — no technical background needed. Open this file in a Markdown preview with Mermaid enabled to see the diagrams. Each diagram also lives as its own file in `docs/diagrams/` (open any `.mmd` file with your Mermaid extension).

1 . What is CourseBridge?

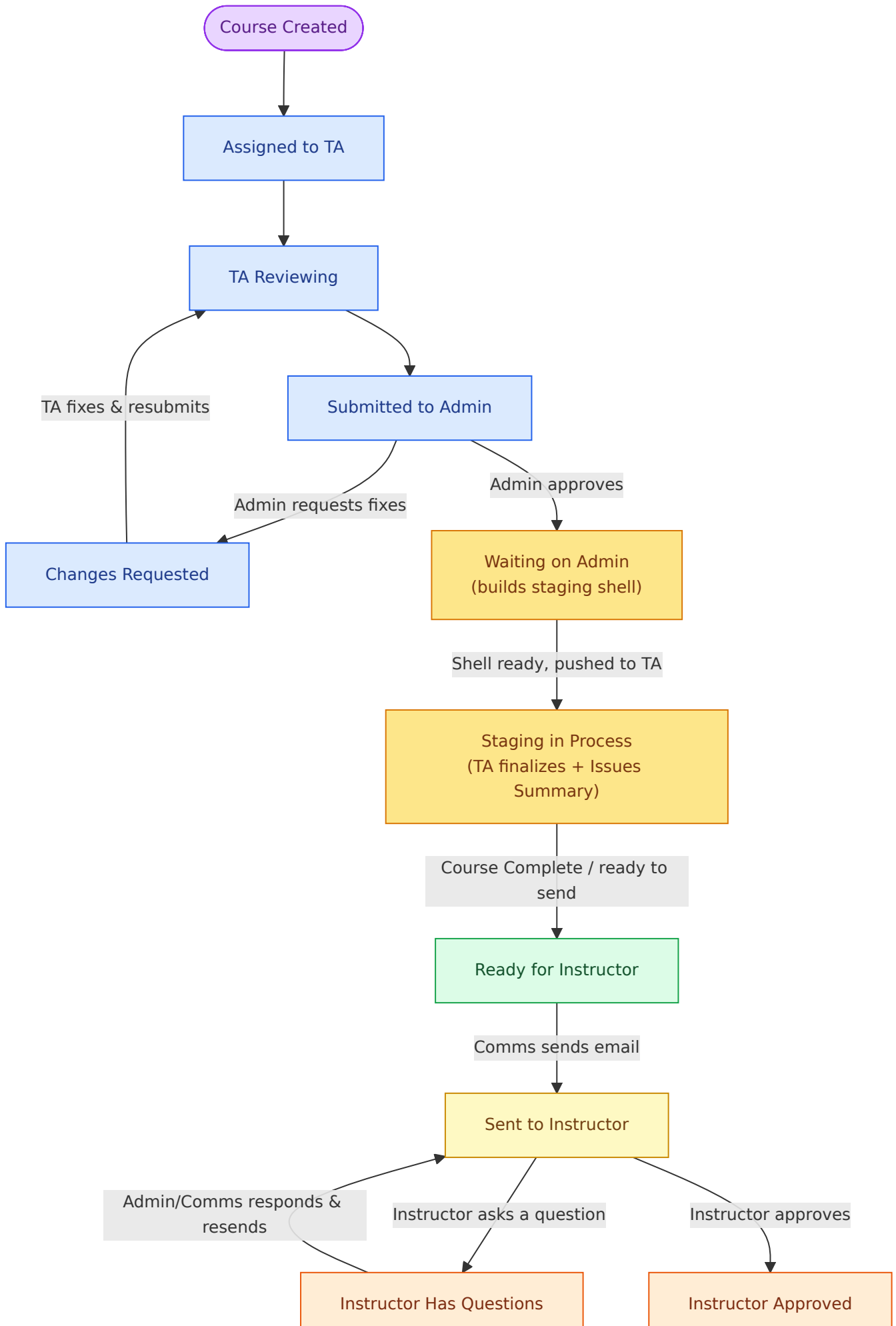
When a course moves from the old system (Moodle) to the new system (Brightspace), someone has to **check that nothing broke** — the syllabus, the grades setup, the files, the links. CourseBridge is the tool that **manages those reviews from start to finish**.

Think of each course as a **case file** that travels through a series of desks. At each desk a specific person does their part, then passes it along. Nobody can skip a desk, and the system always knows exactly where every course is.

2 . The five people involved

Role	In plain words	What they mainly do
TA (Staff)	The reviewer	Opens an assigned course, checks everything, fills the review forms, submits it — and later finalizes the course in staging
Admin	The gatekeeper	Assigns courses to TAs, checks the TA's work, builds the staging shell, approves or sends it back
Communications	The messenger	Sends the approved course package to the instructor
Instructor	The course owner	Looks over their migrated course, asks questions or approves
Super Admin	The manager	Manages users, sees everything, full audit history

3 . The big picture (the whole journey)



Admin gives final sign-off

Final Approved

Read it as a story:

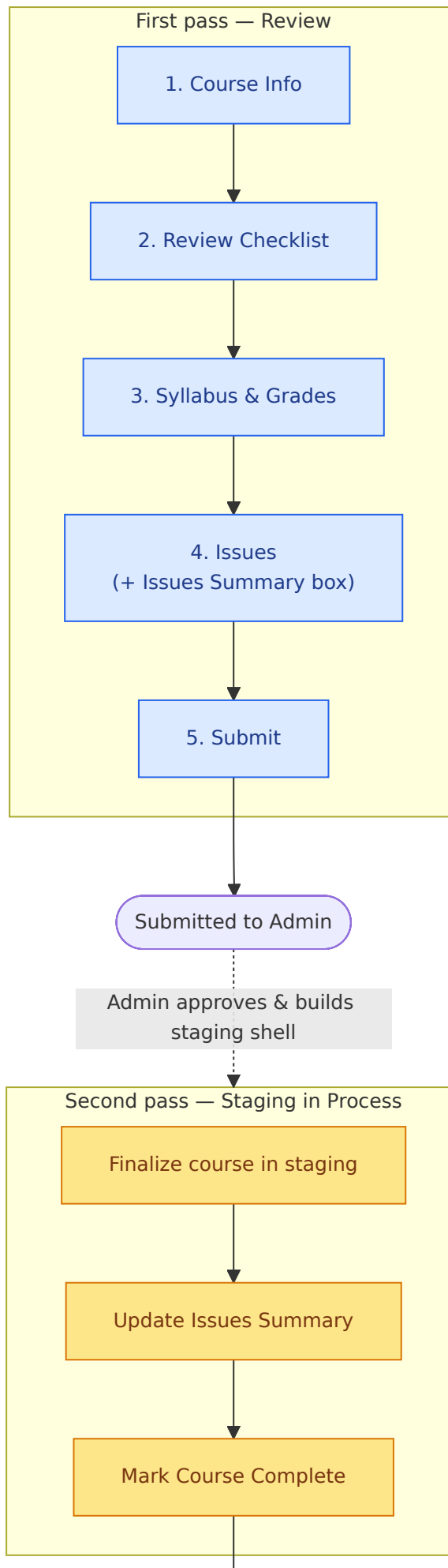
1. A course is created and **assigned to a TA**.
2. The **TA reviews** it and **submits** to the Admin.
3. The **Admin** either **approves** it or **sends it back for fixes**.
4. On approval the course **waits on the Admin** to build the **staging shell**.
5. When the shell is ready it's **pushed back to the TA** as **Staging in Process** — the TA finalizes the course and writes the **Issues Summary**.
6. The TA marks **Course Complete** → the course is **Ready for Instructor**.
7. **Communications** sends the email to the Instructor.
8. The **Instructor** asks questions or **approves**.
9. The Admin gives **final sign-off** — the course is done.

NEW **What's new (steps 4 - 6):** the amber boxes — *Waiting on Admin* and *Staging in Process* — are a newly added phase between "Submitted to Admin" and "Ready for Instructor". See the dedicated diagram in [docs/diagrams/07-staging-phase.mmd](#).

4. Each role, step by step

4 a. TA (the reviewer) —

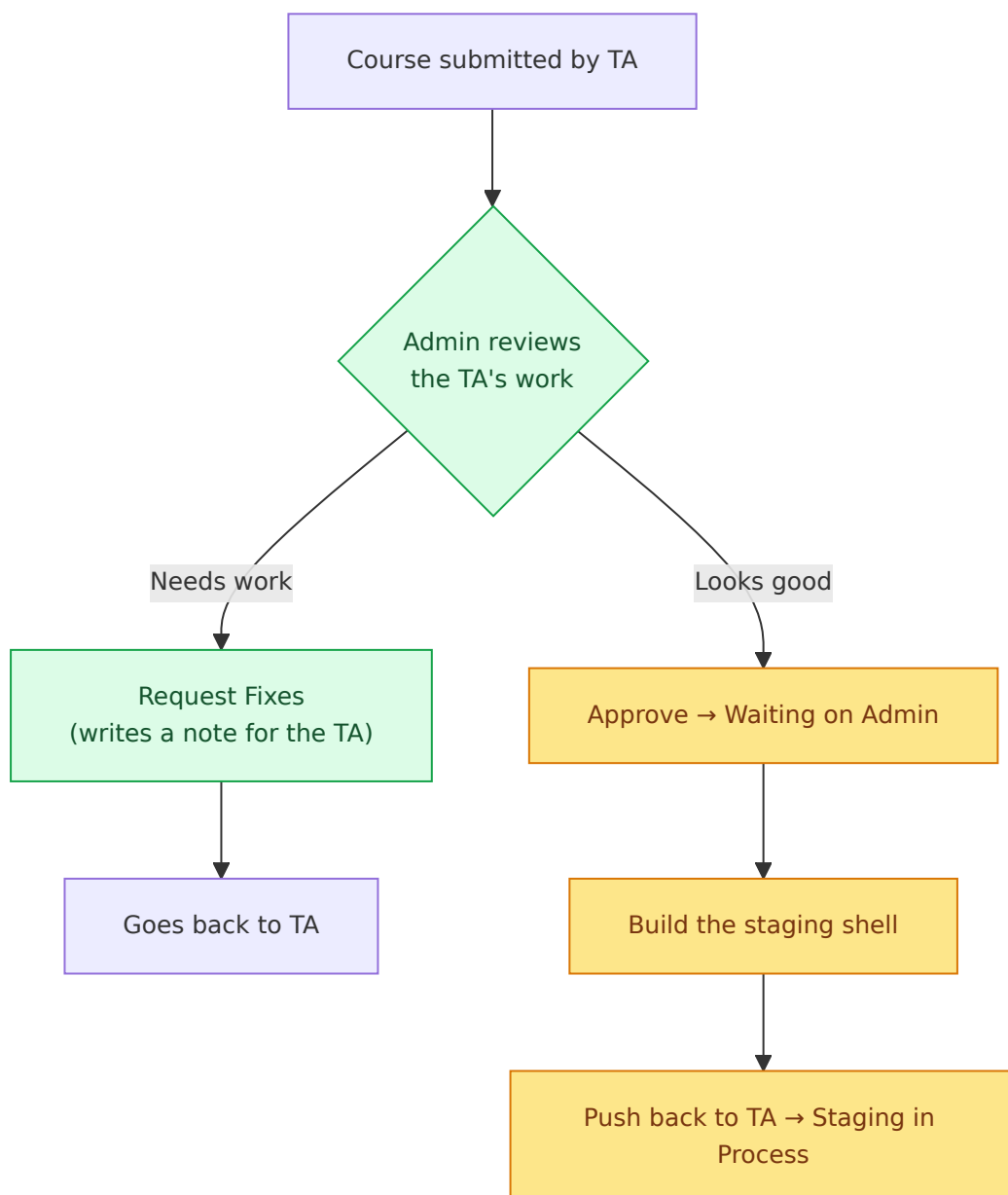
The TA does the hands-on checking. Their work happens in a **5-step workspace**:



Ready for Instructor

- Each step can be **saved as a draft** and finished later.
- A **progress bar** shows which steps are done (green checkmarks).
- If the Admin sends the course back, the TA sees the **Admin's note explaining what to fix**, makes changes, and resubmits.
- NEW After the Admin approves and builds the staging shell, the course comes **back to the TA** as **Staging in Process**. The TA finalizes the course, updates the **Issues Summary**, and marks **Course Complete** when it's ready to send.

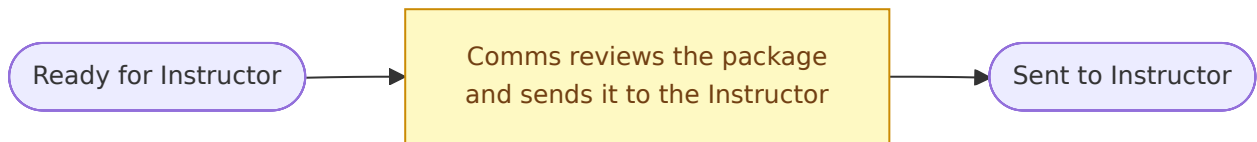
4 b. Admin (the gatekeeper) — ■



The Admin also:

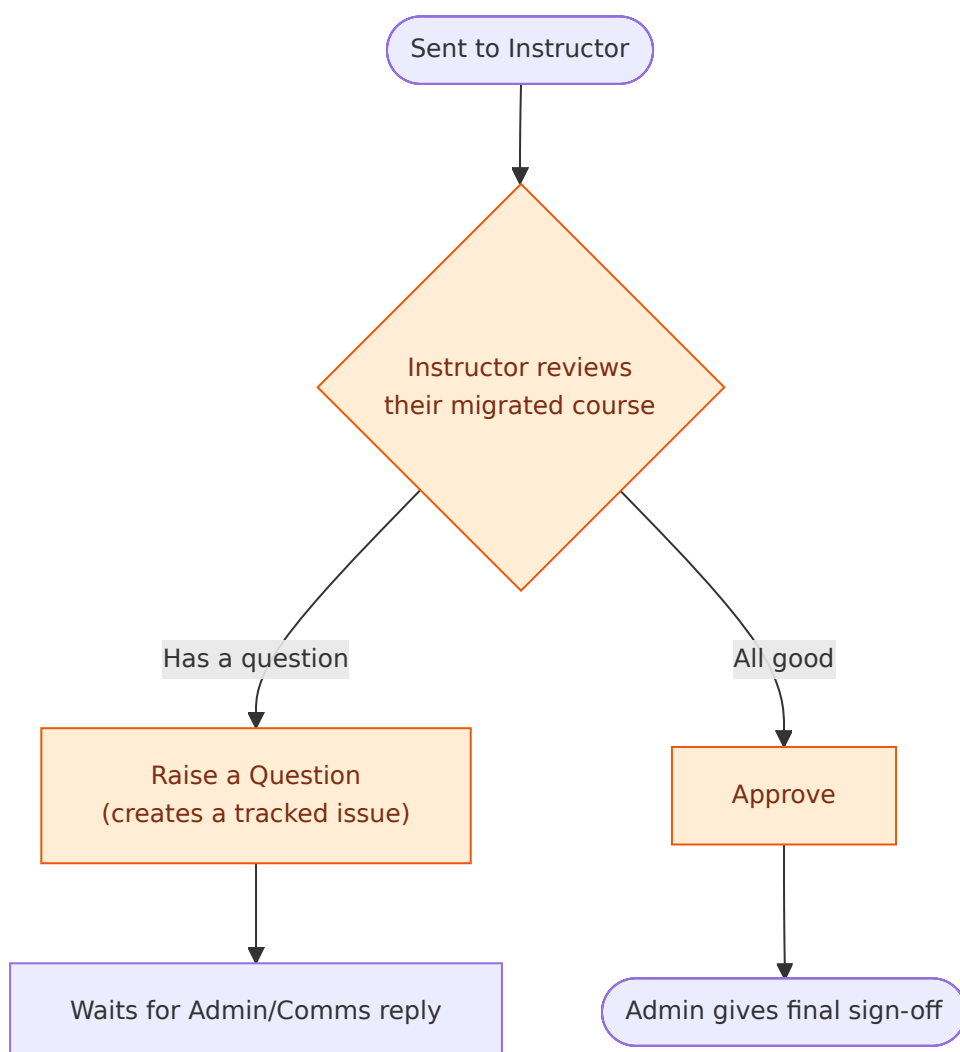
- **Assigns** courses to TAs and instructors.
- **NEW Builds the staging shell** during *Waiting on Admin*, then pushes the course back to the TA.
- Can **edit the Issues Summary** alongside the TA.
- Sees an **Overview dashboard** (totals, workloads, what's pending).
- Handles **escalations** (see section 5).
- Gives the **final sign-off** after the instructor approves.

4 c. Communications (the messenger) — ■



Communications is a focused role: they take an **approved** course and **hand it to the instructor**. If the instructor has questions, Comms (or Admin) responds and **resends**.

4 d. Instructor (the course owner) — ■



The instructor sees a **read-only view** of the TA's review, a **Questions** area, and a **Discussion** thread shared with the TA and Admin.

4 e. Super Admin (the manager) —

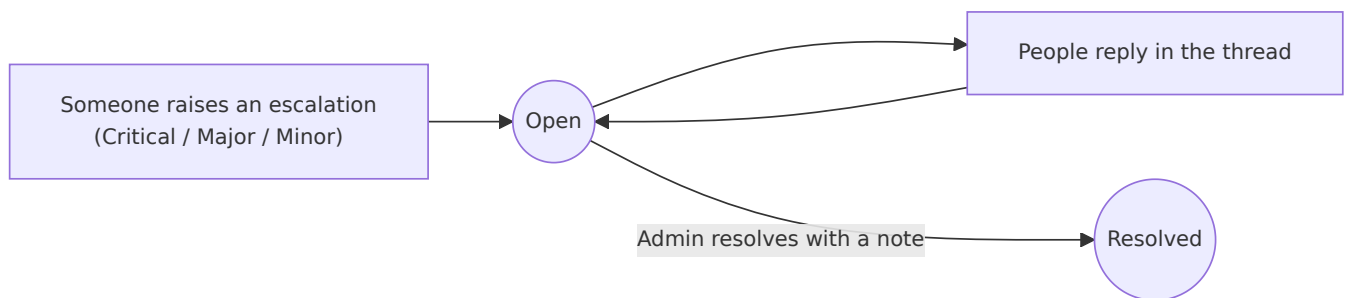
The Super Admin can do everything any other role can, plus:

- **Manage users** and the **organization** structure.
- See the **full audit log** — every status change, who did it, and when.
- View **system-wide analytics**.

5. Things that happen alongside the main flow

Escalations — "something's wrong, flag it"

Anyone can raise an **escalation** (a flagged problem) with a severity: **Critical** / **Major** / **Minor**. It opens a **thread** where people discuss it, and an Admin marks it **Resolved** with a note.



Important: an escalation is a **side conversation**. Resolving it does **not** by itself move the course forward — a person still drives the course through the steps.

Discussions — two separate chat channels

- **Internal chat:** TA ⇌ Admin only (private working channel).
- **Shared discussion:** TA, Admin, Communications, and Instructor all see it.

Notifications

- A **bell** in the top bar shows a count of things needing attention.
- A **Notifications page** lists everything (assignments, actions, issues, comments).



Issues Summary

- A single **free-text summary** of the course's issues, living on the **Issues tab**.
- Editable by **both the TA and the Admin**.

- Finalized during **Staging in Process**, just before the email goes to the instructor — so it travels with the course as a plain-language recap of what was found and fixed.

6. What's NOT built yet (so expectations are accurate)

These are in the plan but **not implemented today**:

Feature	Status
Uploading files / screenshots as evidence	Planned, not built
Exporting a course review as a PDF	Planned, not built
Browser push notifications (alerts outside the app)	Planned — in-app only for now

7. Decided changes (being added now)

-  **New staging phase:** *Waiting on Admin* (admin builds the staging shell) and *Staging in Process* (TA finalizes) now sit between "Submitted to Admin" and "Ready for Instructor".
-  **Course Complete** in *Staging in Process* moves the course straight to *Ready for Instructor*, where Comms/Admin sends the email.
-  **Issues Summary box** on the Issues tab, editable by TA and Admin.

8. Open questions / things we may still change

These are the "rough edges" still worth discussing:

1. **Instructor → TA loop:** Today, if the instructor's question needs the TA to fix something, there's no clean path back to the TA — only back to Comms/Admin.
 2. **Final Approved is the end:** there's no built-in "reopen" if a mistake is found later.
 3. **A bulk "approve to staging" action** can move many courses forward at once, skipping the normal step-by-step checks.
 4. **Submitting** is blocked in the screen until sections look complete, but that completeness isn't enforced deeper down.
 5. **Escalations don't move the course** — but the app already nudges "you can resubmit now" once they're resolved, which suggests people *want* a link between them.
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Diagrams in this document are also available as individual files in `docs/diagrams/` for editing or exporting as images.